relentless, exceptional. The anticipated partnership didn't develop. There aren't many moments when serenity settles, but I looked around and thought, 'This is it.'

It felt almost fated, a reward for faith and application in those stressful net sessions searching for a semblance of form. We felt as if the ball would also nip around when we batted, but conditions caught the deadened mood. Straussy and I didn't feel the need for words when we walked off at the close, with an unbeaten partnership of 157. We simply touched gloves.

The MCG is a great stadium, but doesn't feel like a traditional cricket ground, because of its scale. It's a concrete bowl, and lacks the charm of Adelaide or Cape Town, where the scene is softened by the grass banking. I'll leave you to insert your own joke, but Straussy and I cleared it. The Barmy Army sang 'We can see you sneaking out' at the locals. There were 84,000 in at the start of play; by the end there were about 30,000 Englishmen left.

Memories were created, but nothing had been confirmed. I had a momentary flash of alarm when someone in the dressing room shouted, 'Bat properly here, and we've got the Ashes,' as we prepared to go out after tea. Don't tempt fate. Don't look too far ahead. Simply do your job. I was out quickly the following morning, for 82, and Straussy lasted little longer, but others took our places in the trenches.

Trotty was metronomic, forming adhesive partnerships with KP and Matty Prior, who was reprieved after being mistakenly given out to a no-ball early in his innings of 85. He was unbeaten on 162 when we were bowled out with a first-innings lead of 415. Australia were six down entering the fourth and final day and though Brad Haddin and Siddle put on a few, we were soon doing the Sprinkler Dance on the outfield.

It's simple enough – put one hand behind your back and whirl the other arm – and legend suggests it was originally performed in the eighties. Paul Collingwood rediscovered it; Graeme Swann's video diary ensured it went viral. The occasional fossil, back in England, saw it as another death knell for cricket's dignity, but most saw it for what it was, harmless fun.

The MCG's dressing rooms are cavernous, due to the AFL's need for internal kicking areas, but the ferocity of the celebrations made up for the lack of traditional intimacy. A few of the lads headed out to share the night with the Barmy Army, but something held me back. We had retained the